

A FRAMEWORK IN CHAPTERS

Chapter Two

Rankism

Archism · Rank · Tenurism

The first Fundamental Matrix

Rankism is the system that ranks human beings above and below each other, and turns that ranking into extraction and enforcement. This chapter runs it through the five domains defined in Chapter 1 — from the single triad in a Surulere compound to the national grade-level system that no Nigerian can remember life without.

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CHAPTER 2 OF AN ONGOING FRAMEWORK

Rankism

This is the first Fundamental Matrix chapter. It follows the matrix-chapter template laid out in Chapter 1: definition, then the four domains, then — because Rankism is ascended — the Ascension Ritual with its Canon and Practice, the Intrapersonal Domain it produces, and the moment in living memory when it rewrote history.

A note on method. In the Interpersonal, Disciplinary, and Structural sections, the framework takes the naive approach. Each triad is described as if it were happening for the first time. No networks, no residues, no Canon are mentioned. This is so the nascent form stays visible. The Hegemonic Domain section is where Canon and Practice finally enter the picture.

READING NOTE

Same convention as Chapter 1. Every paragraph is written to be tweetable. Where you see literal blanks (____), the framework is asking you to write yourself into it. The blanks are the difference between reading about Rankism and locating yourself inside it.

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SECTION 1

1. Definition: What Rankism Extracts, Enforces, and Removes

Rankism is the system that ranks human beings above and below each other, then turns that ranking into extraction and enforcement. The word was coined by the American theorist Robert Fuller in *Somebodies and Nobodies* (2003). Fuller argued that rankism is the mother ism: the underlying pattern that racism, sexism, classism, and every other group-based ranking all rely on.

The framework uses Fuller's term but treats Rankism as a fundamental matrix in its own right. It has three faces, which appear throughout this chapter as synonyms: **Archism** (rule by chiefs, principals, and titled figures), **Rank** (the above/below ranking itself), and **Tenurism** (power derived from tenure, seniority, or length of service).

1.1 What Rankism Extracts

Rankism extracts four things. First, **deference**: the labour of attention, the labour of the body (kneeling, standing, bowing), and the performance of subordination. Second, **material tribute**: gifts, 'appreciation', cuts of salary, festive contributions, bribes.

Third, **time**: the hours, days, and years the subject spends waiting on the ranked-superior. Fourth, **decision-making capacity**: the subject's judgment is overwritten by the superior's, so the subject's ability to decide is transferred upward. Each of these is tangible and consequential.

1.2 What Rankism Enforces

Rankism enforces four standards. First, an **address standard**: ranked-superiors must be addressed by title (Sir, Madam, Chief, Professor, Doctor, Your Excellency). Second, a **body posture standard**: ranked-inferiors must kneel, prostrate, stand, lower their eyes, or otherwise assume a subordinate physical position.

Third, a **precedence standard**: ranked-superiors go first. They speak first, eat first, walk through doors first, sit in the front seat. Fourth, a **permission standard**: ranked-inferiors cannot make decisions in their own domain without seeking approval from above.

1.3 What Options Rankism Removes

Concretely, Rankism removes the option to refuse deference without social or economic cost. A graduate who refuses to call the interviewer 'Sir' does not get the job. A junior civil servant who refuses to stand when the director enters is flagged for insubordination.

It removes the option to make autonomous decisions about one's own work, body, time, and resources. It removes the option to be addressed as an equal in any ranked setting. And it removes the option to challenge a ranked-superior without retaliation: a student who challenges a lecturer is failed; a junior who challenges a senior is denied promotion.

Max Weber, in *Economy and Society* (1922), called this the 'authority of the ever-longer duration': the longer a ranking arrangement has been in place, the more natural it feels, and the more expensive it becomes to challenge. Rankism is the oldest and most universal of the fundamental matrices. Every other matrix this framework will study borrows Rankism's grammar of above and below.

SECTION 2 · NAIVE APPROACH

2. The Interpersonal Domain

The Interpersonal Domain is the smallest reproductive unit of Rankism. It contains four enforcement triads and four extraction triads. Each triad is described here as if it were happening for the first time — no networks, no residues, no Canon. Just the act, the conforming subject, the complicit witness, and (for extraction triads) the Non-Extracting Beneficiary.

3.1 Enforcement Triad: Address Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands to be addressed by title or by a specific form of address. A parent, an employer, a senior colleague, a stranger with social power, or a uniformed official could fill this role. The enforcement is performed by issuing the demand directly, by correcting the subject's address, or by punishing 'disrespect' after the fact.

The subject conforms by using the required form: Sir, Madam, Chief, Professor, Doctor, Your Excellency, or whatever title the enforcer demands. The conforming performance is the act of subordination itself. The word is the enforcement.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A job applicant who refuses to address the interviewer as 'Sir' loses access to the job. A market trader who refuses to address a uniformed officer as 'Sir' loses physical safety. A patient who refuses to address the consultant as 'Doctor' loses access to care. Each refusal carries a specific, consequential cost.

The witness is the person who hears the demand and says nothing, or who themselves uses the required form and so models compliance. The witness's complicity is structural: their silence tells the enforcer that the demand is legitimate, and tells the subject that compliance is the safe choice. The witness is not personally benefiting from the specific enforcement.

3.2 Enforcement Triad: Body Posture Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands a specific body posture from the subject. Kneeling, prostrating, standing when the enforcer enters, lowering the eyes, removing a hat, or stepping aside. The enforcement is performed by issuing the demand, by signalling disapproval when the subject does not assume the posture, or by physical correction.

The subject conforms by assuming the posture. The conforming act is the body itself. There is no argument to make against a posture demand that has already been performed — the body has already answered.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A child who refuses to kneel when greeting an elder loses the right to remain in the elder's compound. A junior employee who remains seated when the director enters loses the right to remain employed. A woman who refuses to lower her eyes loses the right to be

considered ‘respectable’ — which is to say, she loses access to spaces and institutions that require respectability.

The witness is the person who watches the posture demand and does not intervene, or who themselves assumes the posture alongside the subject. The witness’s complicity makes the demand a system rather than an incident. Without the witness, the demand is the enforcer’s personal cruelty; with the witness, it is Rankism.

3.3 Enforcement Triad: Precedence Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands to go first. To speak first in a meeting. To eat first at the table. To walk through the door first. To sit in the front seat of the car. To be served first at the counter. The enforcement is performed by waiting, by signalling, by directing the subject to wait, or by punishing the subject who goes first.

The subject conforms by yielding. The yielding is the act of subordination. The subject who refuses to yield is the subject who is punished — rarely physically, more often socially: the refusal is remembered and quoted against the subject later.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A junior doctor who speaks before the consultant in a ward round loses the consultant’s goodwill, which is to say, loses access to the consultant’s training, recommendation, and the consultant’s signature on the registrar’s logbook. A daughter-in-law who eats before her mother-in-law loses the right to be considered a good wife, which is to say, loses the security of her marriage.

The witness is the person who watches the yielding and does not intervene. The witness’s complicity is to themselves yield when their turn comes, and to remember who did not yield. The witness is the keeper of the precedence book.

3.4 Enforcement Triad: Permission Standard

The enforcer is the person whose approval the subject must seek before acting. The parent whose permission the child needs to leave the house. The husband whose permission the wife needs to work (this overlaps with Cisheteropatriarchy, which we will study in Chapter 4). The head of department whose permission the lecturer needs to publish. The chief whose permission the subject needs to farm a piece of land.

The enforcement is performed by withholding approval, by threatening consequences if the subject acts without it, or by retroactively punishing the subject who acted without approval — even when the act itself was harmless.

The subject conforms by seeking approval, by waiting, by accepting the decision. The conforming act is the seeking itself: each time the subject asks, they perform the subordination.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A worker who cannot make decisions in their own domain loses the option to plan their own work, which is to say, loses the option to develop competence, which

is to say, loses the option to be promoted on merit. A wife who cannot leave the house without permission loses the option to earn, which is to say, loses the option to leave the marriage.

The witness is the person who knows the subject must seek approval and does not intervene, or who themselves seek approval from their own enforcer and so model the pattern. The witness's complicity normalises the demand.

3.5 Extraction Triad: Deference

The extractor is the person who requires performance of deference. The greeting ritual, the standing, the bow, the waiting, the 'good morning, sir'. The extraction is performed by summoning, by signalling, or simply by being present — the subject knows to perform.

The subject conforms by performing. What is extracted is the labour of attention and the labour of body. The performance itself is the resource: the extractor is receiving the subject's subordination, in real time, as a kind of social calorie.

The options the subject loses are concrete. Every minute spent in deference performance is a minute not spent on the subject's own life. Over years, the cumulative loss is the option to develop one's own attention, one's own body, one's own presence in the world. The subject becomes the kind of person who is always performing, never present.

The witness is the person who watches the performance and does not intervene, or who performs alongside the subject. The witness's complicity is to receive the reflected deference — the extractor's seniority elevates everyone in the extractor's orbit.

The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the person in the extractor's entourage who is greeted with extra respect because they are seen with the extractor, but who does not personally demand the deference. The chief's friend visiting the compound, the director's personal assistant walking the corridor, the general's aide-de-camp at the mess. They receive deference they did not extract. They are not witnesses because they are personally benefiting.

This role is unstable. The moment the friend, the assistant, or the aide demands the deference for themselves, they become extractors. Most Non-Extracting Beneficiaries drift into extraction over time, because the felt entitlement grows with each received performance.

3.6 Extraction Triad: Material Tribute

The extractor is the person who receives material tribute. Gifts, 'appreciation', festive contributions, cuts of salary, the 'thank you' envelope after a service has been rendered. The extraction is performed by signalling expectation, by the subject's knowledge that tribute is due, or by direct demand.

The subject conforms by giving. What is extracted is tangible: money, food, goods, labour. The extraction transfers resources from the subject to the extractor. If nothing tangible transfers, it is not this triad.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A civil servant who must give a cut of salary to a senior loses the option to feed their family adequately. A market trader who must give festive tribute to the chief loses the option to reinvest in stock. A graduate who must give ‘appreciation’ to the recruiter loses the option to spend that money on rent.

The witness is the person who knows of the tribute and does not intervene, or who themselves give tribute to their own extractor. The witness’s complicity normalises the demand. The witness is not personally benefiting from the specific extraction.

The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the person in the extractor’s household who consumes the tribute but does not personally extract. The chief’s wives and children who eat the yams the subjects brought. The director’s family who live in the house the contractor ‘built for them’. The general’s relatives who ride in the car the supplier ‘gifted’.

The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is unstable here too. The moment the wife, the child, or the relative begins to personally demand tribute — from the household staff, from the extractor’s subordinates, from anyone — they become extractors. Most children of ranked-superiors drift into extraction by early adulthood.

3.7 Extraction Triad: Time

The extractor is the person whose time is treated as more valuable than the subject’s. The extractor is late, cancels, reschedules, or simply does not appear. The subject must wait, return, reschedule around the extractor. The extraction is performed by the extractor’s lateness, absence, or unpredictability.

The subject conforms by waiting. What is extracted is the subject’s time — hours, days, sometimes years of it. The extraction is silent. There is no envelope, no tribute, no performance. There is only the subject’s lost afternoon, lost week, lost year.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The market trader waiting outside the chief’s house loses the option to sell that day. The job applicant waiting in the lobby loses the option to attend another interview. The patient waiting at the clinic loses the option to work, to rest, to be with family. The cumulative loss is the option to plan one’s own life.

The witness is the person who also waits, or who watches the waiting and says nothing. The witness’s complicity is the shared silence of the queue. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the person who skips the queue because they are on the extractor’s schedule — the extractor’s child, friend, or staff — but who does not personally enforce the queue.

3.8 Extraction Triad: Decision-Making Capacity

The extractor is the person whose decision overrides the subject’s. The subject cannot decide; their decision is transferred upward. The extraction is performed by reviewing the subject’s work, by approving or rejecting the subject’s judgment, by overriding the subject’s choice, or by making the decision directly and informing the subject.

The subject conforms by deferring. What is extracted is the subject's decision-making capacity — their judgment, their expertise, their right to be wrong. The extractor now decides not only for themselves but for the subject. The subject's mind has been annexed.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A registrar whose consultant overrides every diagnosis loses the option to develop clinical judgment, which is to say, loses the option to ever become a consultant. A researcher whose head of department rewrites every paper loses the option to develop a voice. A worker whose supervisor approves every action loses the option to act without permission, which is to say, loses the option to be trusted.

The witness is the person who watches the override and does not intervene, or who themselves have been overridden and so model the pattern. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the person who benefits from the override — the extractor's preferred vendor wins the contract because the subject's preferred vendor was overridden — but who does not personally enforce the override.

Nascent forms of this system include: Bullying, Bossing around, Pulling rank, Talking down to, Condescension, Paternalism, Bigmanism, Pecking order, 'Respect your elders', Seniority complex, Yes-man culture, Sycophancy, Bootlicking, Treating someone like a child.

SECTION 3 · NAIVE APPROACH

3. The Disciplinary Domain

When the eight triads above link into networks, Rankism scales. The link can be hierarchical (the enforcer of one triad is the subject of a higher-level triad) or community-based (the witness of one triad becomes the enforcer of another). Both forms are visible in every Nigerian institution. Both reproduce the triads of Section 3 across generations of actors.

4.1 Disciplinary Hierarchy — Nested Stars

A Disciplinary Hierarchy is a chain of nested triads. The enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above. Each middle position is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below. Rankism spreads through this form in every Nigerian institution with a chain of command.

Peak Triad-Node

At the peak is the triad where the highest-ranked enforcer in the hierarchy enforces on the layer directly below. The peak enforcer has no above-them in this hierarchy, so the enforcement is the purest expression of the system's top. The peak extracts deference, tribute, time, and decisions from the layer below, and enforces address, posture, precedence, and permission on them.

In the Nigerian civil service, the peak triad is the Head of Service enforcing on Permanent Secretaries. In a Pentecostal megachurch, the peak triad is the General Overseer enforcing on Provincial Pastors. In a traditional ruler hierarchy in the North, the peak is the Sultan enforcing on Emirs. In a university, the peak is the Vice Chancellor enforcing on Deputy Vice Chancellors.

Middle Triad-Nodes

The middle nodes are where the chain's character is clearest. Each middle enforcer is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below. The Permanent Secretary who kneels for the Head of Service in the morning demands kneeling from Directors in the afternoon. The Director who stands when the Permanent Secretary enters demands standing from Deputy Directors.

The middle is where Rankism reproduces. The subject of today is the enforcer of tomorrow. The middle position teaches the subject to want the position above, which means learning to enforce on those below. By the time the middle enforcer reaches the peak, they have been disciplined by the system for decades. They no longer remember that they once found the kneeling strange.

In the civil service, the middle nodes run from Permanent Secretary (GL 17) down through Directors (GL 15–16), Deputy Directors (GL 14–15), Assistant Directors (GL 13–14), Chief Officers (GL 12), to Officers (GL 07–10). Each layer enforces address, posture, precedence, and permission on the layer below, and is in turn enforced on by the layer above.

Bottom Triad-Node

At the bottom is the triad where the lowest-ranked enforcer in the hierarchy enforces on the public — those who are not in the hierarchy at all. The Police Constable at the checkpoint. The NYSC Corps Member at the orientation camp enforcing on fellow Corps Members a year their junior. The Senior Student in the boarding house enforcing on the Junior Student.

The bottom node is the most violent because the bottom enforcer has the most to prove and the least to lose by proving it. The bottom enforcer enforces hardest because they have been enforced on hardest. The Junior Student who becomes a Senior Student next year remembers every humiliation and reproduces it with interest.

The bottom node is also where the hierarchy meets the community form. The Police Constable at the checkpoint is simultaneously the enforcer in a hierarchy (above the public) and the subject in the same hierarchy (below the Sergeant, Inspector, Divisional Officer, and up). The checkpoint is a node in two directions: the Constable extracts from the public what the Sergeant extracts from the Constable.

4.2 Disciplinary Community — Distributed Network

A Disciplinary Community is a distributed network. There is no peak, no chain of command. There is only circulation. The witness of one triad becomes the enforcer, subject, or witness of another. The pattern spreads laterally through any person who has witnessed the enforcement without dissenting.

How Rankism Spreads Through Community

Rankism spreads through community by silent witnessing. A father in Compound A watches the father in Compound B beat his son for ‘disrespect’. The father in Compound A says nothing. The next week, the father in Compound A beats his own son for the same offence. The pattern has jumped across compound boundaries through the witnessing.

Religion amplifies this. The Pentecostal sermon on ‘honouring the man of God’ circulates the address-and-permission enforcement triads across thousands of households in a single Sunday. The Imam’s Friday sermon on obedience to authority circulates the precedence and permission triads across the mosque network. No central command issues the order. The pattern circulates by repeated witnessing.

The Boarding School as Community

Nigerian boarding schools are textbook Rankism communities. Senior Students enforce address, posture, precedence, and permission on Junior Students. The pattern spreads laterally: a Senior Student in House A watches a Senior Student in House B punish a Junior for ‘not greeting’, then punishes a Junior in House A for the same offence. The Junior who becomes a Senior next year reproduces the punishment.

The 1991 Lagos secondary school drowning — in which a Junior Student was ordered by Senior Students to swim across the school pool and died — was the bottom node of a Rankism community that had spread across Lagos secondary schools through decades of silent witnessing. No single Senior Student invented the demand. The demand was already in the air. The community had been circulating

it for years.

The Compound as Community

The family compound is another Rankism community. The father enforces on his wife and children. The uncle who visits watches and says nothing. The uncle returns to his own compound and enforces the same on his own wife and children. The pattern has spread through the uncle's witnessing.

The compound community reproduces Rankism across generations without any single ancestor issuing the rule. The grandfather who beat his sons for disrespect had himself been beaten by his own father. The father who beats his sons today is reproducing a pattern that has been circulating in the family compound since before anyone currently alive was born.

#EndSARS as Counter-Community

The #EndSARS movement of October 2020 was, briefly, a Rankism counter-community. Witnesses — the young people who had been stopped, beaten, extorted, and humiliated at SARS checkpoints — stopped being complicit. They began to dissent publicly. The dissent spread laterally through Twitter, through the streets, through the protest sites.

The state's response (the Lekki toll gate shooting of 20 October 2020) was a hierarchy reasserting itself through fast death against the dissenting witnesses. The framework treats both moves as analytically legible: the protests were a community breaking a triad; the shooting was a hierarchy restoring one.

SECTION 4 · NAIVE APPROACH

4. The Structural Domain

Run the Ship of Theseus test. When the people in the initial Rankism triads are dead and replaced, when the networks are disbanded and reform, what is consistent? What outlives both individuals and groups? What forces new individuals and groups to re-form into the same patterns — not because anyone instructs them to, but because the residue makes any other pattern costly or invisible?

Rankism leaves all three residues. It is one of the most total systems in the framework. Almost every Nigerian institution carries Bureaucracy, Stratification, and Classification from Rankism simultaneously. The sections below describe each.

5.1 Bureaucracy — Enduring Rules and Procedures

Rankism's bureaucracy is the codified rank structure. The civil service grade level system, created in 1979, organises every federal employee into seventeen levels, GL 01 to GL 17, with salary, office, car, and perquisites tied to level. The original 1979 authors are dead or retired. The bureaucracy lives.

The Armed Forces Act codifies military ranks from Private to General, with court-martial jurisdiction tied to rank. The Universities (Miscellaneous Provisions) Act codifies academic ranks from Graduate Assistant to Professor, with promotion criteria tied to years of service and publications. The NYSC Act codifies the Corps Member, Platoon Commander, Local Government Inspector, Zonal Inspector, and Director-General.

The Chiefs Law of each state codifies traditional ruler stools — the stool of the Oba of Lagos, the Sultan of Sokoto, the Emir of Kano, the Igwe of Nri — with official recognition, salary, and succession rules. The Administration of Estates Laws codify family seniority into inheritance rules: the first son, the eldest daughter, the head of the family, each with defined powers over the estate.

Pension regulations tie retirement benefits to grade level, so that a Director's pension is multiples of an Officer's. The rule was made decades ago. Today's pensioner did not write the rule. The bureaucracy enforces it regardless of the pensioner's intentions or the rule's fairness.

5.2 Stratification — Enduring Zero-Sum Rankings

Rankism's stratification is the daily experience of the rank in every hierarchical encounter. Salary scales tied to grade level. Seat allocation in the office car tied to rank. Walking order in processions tied to rank. Speaking order in meetings tied to rank. The ranking is in the air; it does not need to be announced.

The university faculty meeting enforces stratification without anyone issuing an order. The Professor speaks first, then the Reader, then the Senior Lecturer, then the Lecturer I, then the Lecturer II, then the Assistant Lecturer, then the Graduate Assistant. A Graduate Assistant who speaks before a

Professor is gently reminded — by the silence of the room, by the Professor's look, by the HOD's quiet 'let the senior colleagues go first'.

The traditional ruler's court enforces stratification by seating. The chief sits on the throne. The title holders sit on chairs. The untitled sit on mats. The women sit behind the men. The seating is the rank. Challenging the seating is challenging the rank.

The police checkpoint enforces stratification by stop. The Constable stops the motorist. The motorist stops. The Constable is at the bottom of the police hierarchy, but at the top of the checkpoint triad. The stratification is local and situational, but it is real: at that checkpoint, in that moment, the Constable ranks above the motorist.

5.3 Classification — Enduring Categorical Divisions

Rankism's classification is the set of categorical names that organise every Nigerian into above and below. **Senior** and **Junior** are the universal pair: in school, in the office, in the profession, in the compound. **Staff** and **Management** in the workplace. **Chief** and **Subject** in the traditional ruler context.

Elder and **Young Person** in the family and community. **Principal** and **Student**, **Teacher** and **Pupil** in schools. **Officer** and **Other Ranks** in the military. **Boss** and **Subordinate** in commerce. **Confirmee** and **Trainee** in apprenticeship systems. **Madam** and **Housegirl** in domestic work.

The classification does the work before any individual enforcer shows up. A Junior Doctor walking into a consultant's office is already classified; the consultant does not need to demand deference because the category 'Junior' carries the deference inside it. A Student entering the Principal's office is already classified; the Principal does not need to demand standing because the category 'Student' carries the standing inside it.

Classification is the most universal structural residue. Almost every matrix produces it. But Rankism's classification is the master classification: every other matrix's classification (male/female, adult/child, citizen/foreigner, abled/disabled) is itself ranked by Rankism, so that one of the pair ranks above the other. Rankism is the meta-classification that ranks the other classifications.

SECTION 5

5. The Hegemonic Domain: The Ascension Ritual

Is Rankism ascended? The test from Chapter 1: has it achieved Realism — the sense that it is the way reality works, that there is no alternative, that to challenge it is to challenge a hurricane? Has it retroactively rewritten history? Has it produced a stable Intrapersonal Domain?

Yes on all three. Rankism in Nigeria is ascended. It produces all three structural residues including Stratification (so Internalised Domination applies). It has working Canon and Practice mechanisms. The vast majority of Nigerians cannot imagine a society without rank — despite the fact that some pre-colonial Nigerian societies were markedly less ranked, and the fact that the current rank structure was installed by specific colonial and military decisions within living memory.

6.1 Canon — Rewriting History

Canon is the present belief that rank has always been so. The origination of the structural residues — the civil service grade level system, the military rank structure, the codified traditional ruler stools — has been forgotten. The average Nigerian now takes the rank structure as natural, eternal, and without alternative.

What is forgotten? The Oyo Mesi's power to force the Alaafin of Oyo to commit suicide — a pre-colonial check on royal rank that no longer exists. The Igbo village republics that had no kings and decided affairs by council — a pre-colonial arrangement that the British 'warrant chief' system destroyed in 1900–1930. The Tiv acephalous society — literally 'headless', with no paramount ruler.

Also forgotten: that the British Native Authority system in the North rigidified the Emirate structure into a state-backed hierarchy that had previously been more fluid. That the 1966 military coups brought military rank to the top of civil society, replacing the politician with the General. That the 1979 civil service reform created the GL system out of whole cloth — it is not ancient, it is younger than most living Nigerian pensioners.

Internalised Domination

Canon produces Internalised Domination because Rankism produces Stratification. The senior's felt entitlement to tribute, deference, time, and decisions is now natural, automatic, unquestionable. The Permanent Secretary who expects Directors to stand when entering the room does not experience this as a demand. They experience it as the natural order.

The lecturer who expects students to call him 'Sir' does not feel he is enforcing. He feels he is being accorded his due. The chief who expects festive tribute does not feel he is extracting. He feels he is receiving what is owed. The father who expects his son to kneel does not feel he is dominating. He

feels he is being respected.

The entitlement grows with repetition. The first time the Permanent Secretary entered and Directors did not stand, the Permanent Secretary felt surprise. The hundredth time, the Permanent Secretary feels outrage. The entitlement has been internalised so deeply that its non-fulfilment registers as injury.

Internalised Authority

Canon produces Internalised Authority in the enforcer regardless of personal material gain. The parent who beats the adult daughter for ‘disrespect’ gains nothing material from the beating. The beating does not extract labour or transfer resources. It enforces a standard — ‘daughters obey’ — that the parent has been taught they have a right to enforce.

The uncle who publicly humiliates a niece for ‘addressing him without respect’ gains nothing material. The Senior Student who punishes a Junior for not greeting gains nothing material. The Police Constable who slaps a motorist for ‘arguing’ gains nothing material (the bribe is separate). The right to enforce feels natural, automatic, and legitimate. That is the Internalised Authority.

Internalised Oppression

Canon produces Internalised Oppression in the subject and the witness. The subject is taught that rebellion is impossible, immoral, or pointless. The witness is taught that dissent is dangerous, divisive, or unproductive. The teaching is silent; it is in the air.

The Junior Civil Servant who is told by a colleague ‘that’s how things are’ is being disciplined by Canon. The student who is told by a senior ‘you cannot challenge a lecturer’ is being disciplined by Canon. The woman who is told by her mother ‘you cannot refuse your husband’ is being disciplined by Canon. Each internalises the impossibility of refusal.

Frantz Fanon described the deepest form of this in *Black Skin, White Masks* (1952): the colonised subject internalises the coloniser’s frame so deeply that they experience their own liberation as a kind of death. The Nigerian child who has been beaten for disrespect since age four does not experience kneeling as enforcement. They experience kneeling as their own choice. The rebellion-capable subject has become the self-policing subject.

6.2 Practice — Rewriting Reality

Practice is the second mechanism of the Ascension Ritual. The interpersonal triad is repeated, again and again, until it becomes habit. The enforcer forgets they can choose not to enforce. The extractor forgets they can choose not to extract. The subject forgets they can rebel. The witness forgets they can dissent.

Pierre Bourdieu called this *habitus* — the sediment of repeated practice in the body, such that the social order no longer needs conscious compliance because it has become the body’s default. The Nigerian child who learns to kneel when greeting elders is undergoing Practice for Rankism. The body learns. The mind stops questioning.

By the time the child is forty, kneeling is reflex. They do not decide to kneel. The body kneels. The decision was made decades ago, in the repetition, and the body has remembered it ever since. To choose not to kneel would feel, to the forty-year-old, like a kind of amputation. This is what Practice does: it converts choice into reflex, and reflex into identity.

The same is true of standing when the director enters, of calling ‘Sir’, of waiting one’s turn, of seeking permission. Each repeated practice sediments into the body. By adulthood, the subject cannot easily perform the alternative, even when the alternative is permitted. The body has been trained.

Death — Fast and Slow

Practice produces Death. Fast death in Rankism is spectacular: the lynching of the ‘disrespectful’ youth by an elders’ mob; the police killing of the ‘rude’ citizen at the checkpoint; the hazing death in the boarding school (the 1991 Lagos drowning was Rankism fast death); the Boko Haram massacre produced by the rank structure of the insurgency itself.

Slow death in Rankism is quiet. Chronic stress from constant deference. Mental health collapse from years of ‘yes, sir’. The university student driven to breakdown by a lecturer’s exploitation — the student cannot refuse, cannot challenge, cannot escape, and so the body breaks down instead. The civil servant ground down by the GL system, denied promotion by a senior who takes against them, retire at GL 12 with nothing to show for thirty years but hypertension and depression.

Slow death is also the cumulative erasure of the subject’s judgment. The registrar who never became a consultant because the consultant overrode every diagnosis. The researcher who never developed a voice because the head of department rewrote every paper. The wife who never developed a self because the husband decided every decision. Each is alive, technically. Each is dying, slowly, of a self that was never allowed to form.

Ruth Wilson Gilmore’s definition applies: Rankism produces group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death. The group is ‘juniors’ of every kind. The premature death is fast (lynching, hazing, police murder) or slow (stress, breakdown, erasure). Every ascended matrix kills. Rankism kills more quietly than most, because the killing is done by the body of the subject itself.

SECTION 6

6. When Did Rankism Rewrite History?

The framework's historical question: when did Rankism rewrite history in popular living memory, such that the average Nigerian cannot recall a time when its structural residue was not present? This is not a history of how Rankism was built. It is a diagnosis of when the building was forgotten.

Pre-colonial Nigerian societies had rank. But the rank was more fluid than what came after. The Oyo Mesi could force the Alaafin to commit suicide. The Igbo village republics had no kings and decided by council. The Tiv were acephalous. The Hausa city-states had chiefs but the chiefs could be removed. Rank existed, but it was checked.

Colonial indirect rule rigidified rank. The British 'warrant chief' system in Igboland (1900–1930) installed individuals with state-backed power where no such individuals had existed. The Native Authority system in the North formalised the Emirate structure into a state hierarchy with salary, police, and tax powers. Rank became fixed, state-backed, and unaccountable.

The 1966 military coups brought military rank to the top of civil society. Decree 1 of 1966 suspended the constitution and ruled by military decree. The General was now above the politician, the judge, the civil servant. Military rank culture — saluting, 'Sir', chain of command, court-martial — became the template for every other hierarchy.

The civil war (1967–1970) deepened this. The war economy required mass mobilisation under rank. The post-war oil boom (1973–1980) monetised rank through the civil service salary structure. The Universal Primary Education scheme of 1976 generalised the school hierarchy to every Nigerian child. By 1980, the GL system was universal, the military had set the template, and the post-colonial universities had adopted the British academic rank system.

The tipping point in popular living memory: **circa 1980**. For Nigerians born after 1960 — the post-independence generation — Rankism has 'always been'. They cannot recall a time when rank was not the natural order. The Civil War generation (born ~1940s–1950s) was the last to have living memory of alternative arrangements — village councils, removable chiefs, fluid seniority. By 1980, that generation had been displaced from policy-making by the oil-boom technocrats.

What changed in that moment? Two things. First, the oil boom monetised rank so thoroughly that not having a rank-position became economic suicide. Second, UPE (1976) put every Nigerian child through a ranked school system, so that the first generation to grow up entirely inside the new rank structure reached adulthood around 1980. From that point on, the question 'is rank natural?' stopped being asked in popular memory. It was answered, silently, by the architecture of everyday life.

SECTION 7

7. Fill in the Blank: A Self-Examination

The framework asks two questions of every subject of every ascended matrix. The blanks are for you. They are not rhetorical. The point of the framework is not to understand Rankism in the abstract. It is to locate yourself inside it, so that the next time the triad assembles around you, you can see it.

Question 1: When did Rankism rewrite your reality?

When did the system teach you that you could not rebel? The moment was: _____. The year was: _____. The person who first made you feel that challenging them was impossible was: _____. The place was: _____. What you wanted to say but did not was: _____. What you did instead was: _____. What you told yourself about why you did not say it was: _____. The body posture you assumed in that moment was: _____. The form of address you used was: _____. What you lost, in that moment, that you have not got back since, was: _____.

Question 2: How is Rankism causing your Death?

How is the system shortening your life right now? The form of Death I am most afraid of from Rankism is (fast/slow): _____. The specific way it is happening in my body is: _____. (For example: the chronic back pain from years of standing when the director enters; the insomnia from years of swallowing words I wanted to say to my senior; the hypertension from years of 'yes, sir'; the breakdown I had in 20__ that I have never fully recovered from; the relationship I lost because I could not stop performing deference at home.) The matrix's name for what is happening to me is: _____. My own name for it is: _____.

If you filled in the blanks honestly, you have just located yourself inside Rankism. The next time the triad assembles — the next time the senior demands, the next time the body kneels, the next time the word 'Sir' leaves your mouth — you will be able to see the system moving through you. That sight is the beginning of abolition.

SECTION 8

8. Endnotes & References

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Coming Next

Chapter 3 will take up Adultism — the system that ranks adults above the young, extracts deference and obedience from anyone under the adult line, and removes the young's option to make decisions about their own bodies, time, and futures. Adultism overlaps with Rankism at every point — the young are the most universal 'juniors' — but it has its own enforcement triads, its own residues, and its own Canon. The line between Rankism and Adultism is the line between rank-by-position and rank-by-age. The framework separates them so that both can be dismantled.

If you are reading this chapter as part of the framework in progress, the order continues: Chapter 4 is Kinship Normativity, Chapter 5 is Cisheteropatriarchy, and so on through the Fundamental Matrices. Each chapter follows the same template established here. The naive approach in the first three domains. The Ascension Ritual in the fourth. The historical memory trace. The fill-in-the-blank. The endnotes. The pattern is now set.